



Dotcom(e), Dotgo



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Doesn't anyone believe in the Internet anymore?

Well, stock markets all over the world don't seem to. And venture capitalists nowadays don't seem to have much confidence in the Internet either. Add to this the fact that some of the most popular Web sites have had to shut down their services and free e-mail services are turning commercial.

Is Web content going to remain free? Are any of today's popular Web communities going to be around one year from now? Questions like these seem to dominate our thoughts.

But just look beyond these seemingly larger doubts and it is obvious that Internet usage has been increasing consistently all over the world. More people are spending more time on the Internet. This is primarily because it provides them with a relatively inexpensive means to communicate.

However, the implosion of so many dotcoms over the last year seems to have replaced the excessive optimism with an amazing amount of negativity.

Despite any misgivings that might have been created due to the discontinuation of free e-mail services by USA.net and 123India.com, other free e-mail services will always be available. While it is possible that some e-mail service providers will decide that continuing those free services no longer makes 'business sense', it is probable that many others will realise that they have to continue to provide these services to keep traffic coming to their sites. The Microsoft acquisition of Hotmail a few years ago is an example of how free e-mail services helped to increase the popularity of their MSN portal.

The Web also provides people with a means to share their ideas with others. This is unique because it makes it possible to publish and distribute content at a negligible cost. Several Web sites like Anandtech.com and Rediff.com have used the opportunity that this accessible medium of mass communication provides to become tremendously popular and successful media entities. Quite obviously this doesn't guarantee that every Internet property will be successful.

But what the Internet does provide in ample measure is the opportunity for both individuals and businesses to do much more than was ever thought possible. It helps to create an environment in which our talents and ability can pave the way for our success.

For many of us, that's all that we ask for.

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